The keeper climbed the stair each evening with the same slow care, counting the steps under his breath as his father had done before him. Below the tower the sea worked at the rocks without rest, and the gulls rode the wind as if it had been built for them alone. He trimmed the wick, wiped the glass, and set the great lamp turning, so that its beam swept out across the water and back again. On clear nights he could see the lights of the fishing boats far out, small and steady, and he liked to think that they could see his light as well. In the morning he wrote the weather in the log: the wind, the sky, the height of the tide, and any ship that had passed in the dark. The supply boat came once a fortnight, weather allowing, with flour and oil and letters that were always a little older than he wished.

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